was only the previous year, in 1604, that Khusro's mother Man Bai – Salim's first wife, Bhagwant Das's daughter and Harkha Bai's niece – had overdosed on opium, unable to bear the constant friction between her husband, her son and her father-in-law. Salim blames Khusro for it – his son's stubborn refusal to be 'loyal and loving' to him. Khusro has no voice in history, but if it is true that Akbar nurtured a not-so-secret desire to place his grandchild on his throne, it would be no wonder if Khusro became contemptuous of his seemingly worthless father; even less surprising if he held his mother's suicide against Salim.

In brief: Khusro and his father were bitter rivals; and, as inevitably as tobacco found addicts in Hindustan, their fighting elephants were soon eclipsed by the spectacle of Salim's and Khusro's supporters attacking each other. Akbar was 'exceedingly angry, vexed, and enraged', writes Asad Beg, at the scene – his conversation with God interrupted by unruly mobs.

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It isn't clear when this fight happened, but it was either soon before it or soon after, in 'the beginning of winter, when the air was cold, and the constitution became torpid', that Akbar caught a stomach bug.[23]

As he grew increasingly weak, two of Akbar's closest friends and most powerful amirs, Man Singh and Aziz, called a meeting of the senior nobility. The two men – Khusro's maternal uncle and father-in-law respectively – reminded the council that Akbar's feelings towards Salim were 'notorious'; and that the emperor 'by no means wishes [his son] to be his successor'. Instead, they proposed Khusro for the throne.[24]

Salim has been much decried through history for his dissolute ways, but the prince with an eye for art and a taste for wine was of a more flinty disposition than he is given credit for. Salim had managed to win himself strong support during his past few years in Allahabad. Partly this may have been the result of his natural affability; but also, he had been courting conservative Muslim allegiance, even issuing a farman countermanding Akbar's orders to shut down some mosques and prevent prayers in them. 'It was improper on his part to have acted in this manner,' the prince had declared.[25]

As a result, if Khusro had powerful backers at the council, so did Salim.